

Language and Society

Assignment-1

Report

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August 2025

1 Introduction

Conversation 1

The first conversation was observed on a car trip to another college for an Inter-College Competition. I was the only UG2 there and the rest were UG3s and UG4s. So they started to discuss their research-work and coursework. This senior(S1) was also an ESW course TA so he started to talk about his own project he did last year. The whole conversation itself was around 40-45 minutes but I've only chosen this interesting excerpt as the rest of the conversation followed mostly on the technical lines with elaborate technical details.

Conversation 2

This humorous incident was observed during a yoga class. This happened during the commencement of the session where S1 was trying to embarrass her friend who had thrice failed to clear yoga credits. The conversation was all done in jest and the instructor(S2) as well as rest of the attendants seemed to enjoy it. However, the instructor was a little bit concerned too about S3 as she wanted him to complete his sports credit this time and not waste his invaluable time repeating the same course again and again.

Conversation 3

This conversation took place in a canteen where two seniors discussed the recent internship interview. He was thankful to the senior for helping him to crack the interview by giving invaluable guidance. They discussed the technical nuances of the interview while also trying to speculate why some really good students were not able to qualify despite being technical sound with a great resume.

Conversation 4

This conversation was observed during the midnight when I was at the college tea-stall where some other students were stunned to see a chubby dog. They discussed the dog names and played around with the dogs with the area while asking questions about them to one of their friends who seemed to be a part of dog-feeding group. They talked about a lot of stuff but I selected only this conversation as their other conversation ranged from photography to car revving as well as making fun of one their friend's personal relationship.

2 Observation

Conversation 1

Speaker	Perceived Age/Gender	Context	Speech Snippet	Features
S1	early 20s, male	ESW Project	“Last year, we had some issue with the QIDK documentaion so we met with the Qualomm representative and he told us that the person who worked on it is no more in the company so its difficult to fix.”	informal register, technical discussion
S2	early 20s, male	ESW Project	“That’s so crazy! So how did you guys manage to pull it off then?”	informal register, technical discussion
S1	early 20s, male	ESW Project	“So what happeneed was there wass Meagthon in between the semester. The same guy was the one who realeased the problem statement. Guess what the statement was? The same issue! So we braced ourseleves and solved the issue throughout the night, won Megathon as well got done with our ESW project.”	informal register, technical discussion

Conversation 2

Speaker	Perceived Age/Gender	Context	Speech Snippet	Features
S1	early 20s, female	Yoga Class	“Ma’am! This He(S3) is repeating yoga for the third time. You failed him thrice!”	informal register
S2	early 50s, female	Yoga Class	“Anna you should come everyday and complete your sports credits this sem only. Don’t come to me in October and then ask me that ‘Can I attend it everyday’ cause then it would be difficult for me to take so many students at one time.”	informal register
S3	early 20s, male	Yoga Class	“Yes ma’am, I’ll try to complete yoga this semester. Couldn’t find the motivation before.”	informal register
S1	early 20s, female	Yoga Class	“That’s why I’m here! I definitely didn’t fail yoga.”	sarcastically, informal register
S2	early 50s, female	Yoga Class	“If you need more motivation, you can bring more of your friends here. I have no issue. Just complete your yoga credits on time. If you want give me your number and I will call you everyday to remind you to attend the class but please complete your credits on time.”	informal register

Conversation 3

Speaker	Perceived Age/Gender	Context	Speech Snippet	Features
S1	early 20s, male	Intern Drive	“Thanks for helping with the interview today!”	informal register
S2	early 20s, male	Intern Drive	“Aree no problem, you got the intern right.”	informal register
S1	early 20s, male	Intern Drive	“Yeah but it was tough, I mean D(retracted for privacy reasons) didn’t get in . I don’t know how I got it but I think it’s because I explained the brute force method first and then the optimal solution. I mean D gave the right answer but he did so directly, I can’t exactly say why they selected me but him and several other fodu people.”	informal register
S2	early 20s, male	Intern Drive	“Tu apne aap ko underestimate kyu kr raha? Aise mat socha kar. You are really good yourself.”	informal register
S1	early 20s, male	Intern Drive	“Nahi, it’s like D had 9+ cg and a really good CV so I think the only good reason would be his approach not being good according to them.”	informal register
S2	early 20s, male	Intern Drive	“Acha maybe aisa hi ho. I have to go right now. See you later!”	informal register

Conversation 4

Speaker	Perceived Age/Gender	Context	Speech Snippet	Features
S1	early 20s, male	Tea Stall	“Look at this guy(pointing towards the dog).”	informal register
S2	early 20s, male	Tea Stall	“It’s so chonky! It’s Gopi right?”	informal register
S3	early 20s, male	ESW Project	“No, no, this is Chintu. Yeah he’s a big boi(holding his belly fat).”	informal register
S1	early 20s, male	Tea Stall	“I would not be taking it so lite if S3 did that to me(to S2).”	humourously, informal register
S2	early 20s, male	Tea Stall	“Yeah bro! he just violated Chintu like that. ”	laughingly, informal register
S1	early 20s, male	Tea Stall	“What are these other guys name.(Pointing towards dogs)”	informal register
S3	early 20s, male	ESW Project	“This one’s Leon and the other one is Jeff.”	informal register
S1	early 20s, male	Tea Stall	“This(pointing towards Jeff) is the aggressive one right.”	informal register
S3	early 20s, male	ESW Project	“Yeah he’s known for being aggressive but he was quite chill before. It’s only after Leon came that he lost his cool.”	informal register

3 Analysis

Conversation 1

The language here is informal register despite being about technical topics. This shows how register adapts to the background setting as the seniors talking among themselves did not use **formal academic style**, but rather **casual conversational English** showing solidarity among the community. This shows that normal everyday speech is different from formal academic discourse, and that authentic observation must record speech “as used naturally” rather than only in formal contexts. The use of engineering and technical **jargon** like QIDK, Qualcomm and Megathon reinforces the speakers’ identity as engineers creating a linguistic limitation for those who don’t belong in this group. The use of terms like “that’s so crazy” and “pull it off” shows usage of modern slangs and vocabulary which signifies the generation identity of speakers and their linguistic modifications to the everyday language.

Conversation 2

The students address the instructor in a somewhat respectful but still in an informal tone, while joking within their peers sarcastically. This style shift highlights how speakers move between solidarity-building humor and authority-oriented respect depending on the participant addressed. According to sociolinguistics, such shifts represent how context and participant relationships affect code choice and style. The concern of the the instructor about the student passing the course also show her professional commitment towards her students success and strengthen the social bonds between them.

Conversation 3

This interaction includes Hinglish code-mixing (“Tu apne aap ko underestimate kyu kr raha”), which reflects a bilingual peer-group. Code-switching here emphasizes solidarity among the peer-grpup. Variationist sociolinguistics (Labov, Trudgill) treats such mixing as structured variation linked to social identity (youth, student group). This also shows how speakers negotiate prestige and self-evaluation through language.

Conversation 4

The group employs in-group slang and playful lexis (“chonky”, “big boi”), echoing peer-group in-group slang and playfulness. This kind of language generates solidarity and signals membership in a student group. Hernández-Campoy observes that ethnographic study in informal peer settings uncovers how humor and slang act as social bonding techniques, which holds here. The whole exchange is extremely casual and situational, just the kind of “real-world linguistics” sociolinguists analyze in order to learn about language in its natural social environment. The humor (“he just broke Chintu”) depends on shared knowledge and rapport among the group

4 Conclusion

These findings support the idea that social context has a significant impact on language use. Slang, code-mixing, and informal registers predominated among peers (tea stall, canteen), indicating camaraderie and group affiliation. Style-shifting took place in mixed authority settings (yoga classes) to strike a balance between peer humor and respect for authority. Even complicated subjects were discussed informally during the car trip, demonstrating that register is more about speaker relationships and context than it is about subject matter.

Methodologically, the assignment avoided the observer’s paradox (Labov) by using the ethnographic field-work approach that is stressed in sociolinguistics: observing naturally occurring speech without recordings. The results are consistent with sociolinguistic research methodologies that emphasize the connection between linguistic variation (register, code-switching, slang) and extralinguistic factors (age, role, context).

To put it briefly, the data supports the fundamental sociolinguistic finding that language variation is socially meaningful, patterned, and reflects the identities, relationships, and contexts of its speakers.